Abbasid Caliphates, the Spanish and Portuguese Empires, and successive Chinese dynasties attempted to establish hierarchical international orders that often drew legitimacy from religion: the Caliph in the Islamic world, the Pope in Western Christendom, or the ‘Son of Heaven’ in Imperial China. By contrast, the modern international order is grounded in the notion of sovereignty—that a state has supreme domestic power, freedom from foreign interference, and equality with other states—confirmed at the Treaties of Westphalia in 1648. Today, the idea of Westphalian sovereignty sits uneasily with notions of universal ideals or normative values. Even when attempts were made to articulate and enforce universal norms—as after the American, French, and Russian Revolutions—notions such as a balance of power and colonial control took precedence in practice.

India has often felt the impact of norms defined by others, but its pre-colonial history also shows glimpses of an ability to establish normative standards for itself and the world. There are good reasons, then, for India to articulate and implement its own vision of international norms, at times in conjunction with like-minded partners. For India today, this will require drawing broader lessons from the Indian experience. Indeed, why should the lived experience of the most populated country in human history not have wider—perhaps even universal—applications? But it will also require investments in scholarship, which would benefit from more assiduous recordkeeping, the preservation of relevant documentary and material evidence, and their greater accessibility. Ultimately, the articulation and enforcement of norms and values will require aligning words with deeds and power with persuasion. In fact, some of these challenges were already apparent as India emerged as an independent republic in the middle of the twentieth century.